EMPLOYEE EXPERIENCE

Everybody Knows Who to Ask. Only She Knows the Answer.

Turn one expert's repeat judgment into guidance the next person can actually use.



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Your senior estimator is on vacation. A facilities manager wants to know whether you can price repairs from photos alone. A junior rep sees photos, an address and a due date. She's about to confirm. If the senior estimator were there, she'd ask whether the photos show the full affected area and when it was last repaired. On one property, she'd remember that the records for an earlier job described a different problem.

The junior rep knows where the files are. What she needs is to know which detail changes the next step.

To make company knowledge usable beyond one person, start with a decision people regularly bring to that expert. Capture the facts they check, why those facts matter, when the guidance applies, and when someone must escalate. Put it where the next employee works and test it on real examples.

What knowledge is worth writing down first?

Start with a recurring decision that delays work or becomes risky when one person is unavailable. Watch how the expert handles a normal case and an exception. Compare the records, the questions they ask, and the point where their answer changes.

If you're halfway through assembling a cabinet and a small bracket is missing, IKEA's U.S. guidance tells you to find the instructions by product name or article number, then use the part number in the instructions to identify the missing piece. It makes the answer findable from the thing in front of you. A service company can do the same with a site, product or job record. Start with what an employee can see when the question comes up. IKEA on finding assembly instructions · IKEA on identifying a missing part

Try that with your estimate request. Can the rep see past work from the same location while the customer is on the phone? Can she tell when a photo-based budget is appropriate and when a firm price needs someone on site? If the only person who knows those limits has to be available, start there.

What should a useful knowledge entry contain?

Give the employee the decision, the conditions they can check, the relevant source, and the person who handles exceptions. Include an example where the standard answer applies and one where it changes. Give the entry an owner and an event that triggers review.

Field	Example for a photo-based repair inquiry
Question people actually ask	“Can I get a price from these photos?”
Standard answer	A preliminary range may be possible if the affected area and scope are visible and site records agree.
What to check	Location, current photographs, known earlier work and what the customer will use the price for.
When to escalate	Damage extends beyond what can be seen, records conflict, or the customer needs a firm commitment.
Owner and update trigger	Estimating lead. Review when scope rules change or a new exception appears.

This **Knowledge Use Record** describes how the rep can move the conversation forward. Put it beside the estimate request, with a link to earlier work at that location. A searchable library can help employees find the entry. The placement matters when a rep has the caller on hold and ten minutes before the next appointment.

How do you capture a judgment the expert makes by feel?

Ask the expert to compare two completed decisions with different answers. On one repair request the photos covered every affected area and the records showed a recent, limited repair. On another the photos showed the same symptoms and the earlier work described a different underlying condition. Ask the estimator to point to the first detail that made her change course.

Turn the answer into a condition someone else can check. “Escalate tricky repairs” still asks the rep to share the expert’s instinct. “Check for earlier work at this address. If the record describes a different cause from the one the customer reports, ask the estimator to review before giving a firm price” gives the rep a task she can do. The expert can explain why the condition matters and decide what can be handled on the next request without her.

How do you know someone else can use the guidance?

Give a colleague two redacted cases without the expert present. Ask what they would tell the customer, which facts support it, and what they would do if an input were missing. Have the expert review the decisions and identify the useful condition that is still implicit.

If the rep used the article and still promised a firm quote from incomplete photos, ask where the guidance let her make that decision. Add the condition or make the source easier to find. If she escalated every request, find out which fact the guidance requires her to verify and whether she can

actually get it. Keep one person responsible for updates when policies, people, products, or exceptions change.

Three checks before a team relies on an entry.

- It says what someone can decide and which facts they need.
- It is available at the point where they will decide.
- It shows where the standard answer ends and who can take over.

The next time the estimator is away, the rep can give the facilities manager a useful first answer and tell them what will make a firm price possible. The specialist can come in when the case calls for her.

Frequently asked questions

Should every expert conversation be recorded?

Capture recurring decisions and meaningful exceptions first. Check permission and keep only information the next employee needs. A short, maintained entry will often be easier to use than a full recording.

Can a search assistant replace the knowledge owner?

It can help find an approved answer. Someone still needs to maintain the source, define where it applies, and handle exceptions that require a decision.

What should happen to outdated guidance?

Remove it from the active path and preserve history where the business needs it. Point readers to the current version and show who can confirm uncertain cases.

The service firm is illustrative. The furniture example draws on IKEA's public guidance.